CONDUCTING THE IELTS SPEAKING MOCK TEST

A Teacher Training Handbook for Standardized Practice, Fair Administration, and Reliable Scoring

Prepared for Teacher Development and Internal Examiner Standardization

Based on Official IELTS Band Descriptors and Standardized Assessment Principles

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Foreword

This handbook has been developed to address a persistent gap in language education practice: the significant difference between teaching a student to speak English and assessing a student's speaking proficiency under standardized conditions. Many excellent language teachers, when placed in the role of examiner, instinctively revert to their pedagogical habits — supporting, correcting, encouraging, and simplifying. These are admirable instincts in the classroom. In a standardized speaking assessment, however, they undermine the very purpose of the test.

The IELTS Speaking Test is a formal assessment instrument, and any mock test conducted in preparation for it must reflect the conditions, expectations, and standards of the real examination as closely as possible. When it does not, students receive distorted feedback, inaccurate band estimates, and false confidence or false alarm — none of which serve their preparation.

This handbook provides teachers with the knowledge, protocols, and practical tools to conduct mock speaking tests with the neutrality, consistency, and professional discipline required of a standardized examiner. It covers every stage of the test, from room setup and opening greetings to post-test feedback and team calibration.

Whether you are delivering your first mock speaking test or refining established practices, this handbook is designed to be your primary reference document. It should be read, discussed, and consulted regularly — not treated as a one-time orientation document.

The goal is not to turn teachers into robotic testing machines. It is to help teachers develop the professional awareness needed to separate their dual identities: the warm, supportive educator, and the impartial, consistent examiner. Both have their time and place. This handbook is about knowing the difference.

CHAPTER 1

Understanding the Purpose of the IELTS Speaking Mock Test

1.1 What the IELTS Speaking Test Is Designed to Assess

The IELTS Speaking test is a structured, one-on-one oral interview designed to assess a candidate's ability to communicate effectively in spoken English across a range of topics and communicative contexts. It is not a test of knowledge, general intelligence, cultural familiarity, or personal opinion. It measures the quality and range of a candidate's spoken language through four distinct band descriptors:

- Fluency and Coherence — the ability to speak continuously, logically, and with appropriate pacing
- Lexical Resource — the range, accuracy, and appropriateness of vocabulary used
- Grammatical Range and Accuracy — the variety and correctness of grammatical structures employed
- Pronunciation — the clarity, intelligibility, and use of phonological features in speech

Each descriptor is assessed holistically over the course of the entire test, with a band score from 1 to 9 assigned per criterion. The overall Speaking band is the average of the four descriptor scores. Importantly, these criteria are assessed independently: a candidate may demonstrate strong fluency but weak pronunciation, or a broad lexical resource alongside limited grammatical range. Examiners — and by extension, teachers conducting mock tests — must assess each criterion on its own merits, based on evidence gathered throughout the test.

1.2 Why Mock Tests Matter

A properly conducted speaking mock test serves several critical functions in a student's IELTS preparation journey. When administered correctly, it provides the student with an authentic experience of examiner interaction, timing, question style, and performance pressure. It allows the student to practise transitioning between the three parts of the test, managing anxiety under real conditions, and demonstrating language use without teacher support.

Equally important, a well-run mock test provides the teacher with meaningful diagnostic information. It enables the teacher to observe the student's actual speaking proficiency — not their classroom performance or their performance when scaffolded and supported — and produce a band estimate that reflects what the student is likely to achieve in a real examination. This estimate is only reliable if the mock test conditions closely replicate real examiner behavior.

A poorly conducted mock test, conversely, produces misleading data. If a teacher-examiner prompts too much, re-explains questions, praises responses mid-test, or simplifies language, the student's performance is artificially elevated. The teacher may then assign a band score that is higher than the student's genuine capability, leading to unpreparedness on test day.

DEFINITION: Test Validity

The degree to which a test measures what it claims to measure. In the context of the IELTS Speaking mock test, validity refers to whether the mock test accurately reflects the conditions, demands, and assessment criteria of the actual IELTS Speaking examination.

1.3 The Difference Between Language Teaching and Language Assessment

This distinction is fundamental and must be internalised by every teacher conducting a mock speaking test. Teaching and assessment are not the same activity. They operate on different principles, require different behaviors, and serve different purposes.

Dimension	Language Teaching	Language Assessment
Primary Goal	Develop the student's language ability	Measure the student's current language ability
Teacher Role	Facilitator, coach, guide	Neutral observer and evidence collector
Student Error	Corrected or addressed	Noted but not corrected
Interaction Style	Supportive, encouraging, adaptive	Standardized, consistent, non-leading

Question Type	Scaffolded, graded for difficulty	Pre-determined, standardized across candidates
Feedback	Given during and after interaction	Given only after the test is fully complete
Outcome	Improved language performance	A band score based on performance evidence

The failure to make this distinction leads to what is perhaps the most common and damaging error in mock test administration: the teacher who conducts the test as an extended lesson. This invalidates the mock test entirely and denies the student the benefit of a genuine pre-examination assessment.

1.4 Why Standardization Matters

DEFINITION: Standardization

The practice of ensuring that all candidates are assessed under identical or equivalent conditions, using the same prompts, timing, and examiner behavior, so that scores reflect candidate ability rather than examiner variation.

Standardization exists to protect the fairness of the assessment. When different teachers conduct mock tests in significantly different ways — some offering more time, some re-explaining questions, some expressing approval — the scores they produce are not comparable. A student assessed by a lenient mock examiner may receive a band estimate of 6.5, while the same student assessed by a more standardized teacher might receive 5.5. Neither estimate is reliable unless the test was conducted consistently.

In institutional settings where multiple teachers assess the same cohort of students, inconsistent administration creates serious inequities. Students may receive wildly different preparation quality depending on which teacher assessed them. Standardization practices — covered in depth in Chapter 11 — are the institutional response to this challenge.

1.5 Why Examiner Behavior Affects Candidate Performance

The examiner is not a passive recording device. The examiner's tone, pacing, body language, and responses directly affect how the candidate performs. Research in oral assessment

consistently shows that examiner warmth, question clarity, and perceived supportiveness influence candidate output — sometimes significantly. This places an ethical and practical burden on the mock examiner to manage their own behavior carefully.

An overly expressive examiner who nods vigorously, smiles broadly at correct answers, or frowns subtly at errors is providing unintentional feedback that can inflate or deflate a candidate's performance. A teacher who gives a slightly longer pause before rephrasing might signal to the student that their answer was inadequate, prompting unnecessary elaboration or anxiety. Even the pace at which the examiner speaks, or the warmth of the opening greeting, can set a tone that either relaxes or heightens candidate anxiety.

This does not mean the examiner should be cold or robotic. It means the examiner must develop a consistently warm, calm, neutral professional manner — one that creates a safe environment for the candidate to perform without providing information about the quality of their performance.

DEFINITION: Examiner Bias
Any systematic tendency on the part of the examiner to award higher or lower scores based on factors unrelated to the band descriptors, such as the candidate's nationality, personality, attractiveness, confidence, or the teacher's prior relationship with them.

1.6 Core Assessment Principles: Validity, Fairness, Consistency, and Reliability

Teachers conducting mock tests should understand four foundational principles that govern all professional language assessment:

Principle	Definition	Practical Implication for Mock Examiners
Validity	The test measures what it claims to measure	Conduct the test in a way that elicits genuine language performance, not coached or supported speech
Fairness	All candidates are treated equitably	Apply the same procedures, timing, and language to every candidate

Consistency	The same standards are applied across assessments	Use the same examiner behavior regardless of which student is being assessed
Reliability	The test produces stable, reproducible scores	Base scores on concrete evidence, not impressions or preferences

1.7 Why Mock Tests Must Not Become Casual Conversations

One of the most common and well-intentioned errors teachers make is allowing the mock test to drift into a comfortable conversation. The teacher knows the student. They share rapport, history, and often, genuine fondness. It feels unnatural and even unkind to adopt a formal, neutral examiner persona with a student one has taught for months.

However, this naturalistic drift is highly damaging to the validity of the mock test. When the test becomes a conversation, several problems occur:

- The candidate's performance reflects their ease with a familiar person, not their ability under test conditions
- The teacher unconsciously accommodates, simplifies, and supports in ways a real examiner would not
- Timing discipline collapses, as the teacher extends parts when the student is interesting and shortens them when the student struggles
- The resulting score reflects the quality of the relationship rather than the quality of the language

The mock test must be conducted as a distinct, bounded event — different in character from every other interaction the teacher and student have had. This requires a deliberate and consistent mental switch.

1.8 The Teacher vs. the Examiner: A Mindset Shift

The most important single preparation a teacher must make before conducting a mock speaking test is not logistical — it is psychological. The teacher must consciously shift from their default professional identity — supportive educator — to the role of standardized examiner.

✓ DO	✗ DO NOT
Enter the test in examiner mode, not teacher mode	Allow your classroom relationship to affect your examiner behavior
Remind yourself before the test: 'My job is to collect evidence, not to help'	Use encouraging language that signals evaluative feedback
Maintain the same warm-but-neutral tone throughout	Feel responsible for the student's performance during the test
Think of yourself as a fair, professional recorder of performance	Adjust your behavior because you feel sorry for a struggling student
Separate your personal feelings about the student from your scoring	Think of the mock test as an extension of your teaching

REFLECTION & DISCUSSION QUESTIONS
1. In what ways does your classroom teaching style most likely influence your behavior as a mock examiner? What specific habits would you need to suppress?
2. Think of a student you have a strong relationship with. How might that relationship affect your mock test behavior, consciously or unconsciously?
3. What does 'neutral support' mean to you in the context of an oral assessment?
4. Why is it insufficient to simply decide to 'be fair' without understanding what standardized behavior looks like in practice?

KEY TAKEAWAYS
• The IELTS Speaking test measures language ability across four specific band descriptors, not content knowledge or personality.
• Mock tests must replicate real examiner conditions as closely as possible to produce valid and useful data.
• Language teaching and language assessment are fundamentally different activities requiring different teacher behaviors.
• Standardization protects fairness and ensures that scores reflect candidate ability, not examiner variation.
• Examiner behavior directly influences candidate performance; teachers must develop a consistently neutral professional manner.
• The most important preparation for a mock test is the psychological shift from teacher mode to examiner mode.

CHAPTER 2

The Role of the Teacher as Mock Examiner

2.1 Before the Test Begins: Preparation and Setup

The teacher's role as examiner begins well before the student enters the room or the online session commences. Adequate pre-test preparation ensures that the teacher enters the test already in examiner mode, rather than scrambling to switch roles mid-interaction.

Prior to each mock test session, the teacher-examiner should:

- Review the test structure and timing requirements (see Chapter 4)
- Prepare or confirm the Part 2 topic card and ensure it is appropriate for the student's approximate level
- Set up the testing environment (physical or online) so that it is free from distractions
- Prepare note-taking materials organized by band descriptor
- Mentally rehearse the opening script and transitions
- Confirm the timing mechanism (stopwatch, phone, or timer application)
- Ensure that no teaching materials, feedback sheets, or correction prompts are visible during the test

TRAINER NOTE

Encourage teachers to practise the opening script aloud before their first mock test. Teachers are often surprised by how unnatural the formal examiner language feels at first. Repeated practice makes it sound more confident and genuine.

2.2 During the Test: What the Teacher Must Stop Doing

The act of conducting a mock speaking test requires the teacher to consciously suppress a range of deeply ingrained professional behaviors. These behaviors are appropriate and even excellent in teaching contexts. In assessment contexts, they are inappropriate and damaging to validity.

Once the test begins, the teacher must cease all of the following:

- Offering vocabulary when the student appears to struggle
- Reformulating or paraphrasing questions to make them simpler
- Giving any verbal or non-verbal approval of responses (e.g., 'That's great!', vigorous nodding)
- Correcting grammar or pronunciation errors
- Providing topic-related ideas or suggestions when the student cannot think of content
- Extending the test when the student is performing well
- Shortening the test when the student is clearly struggling
- Adapting the difficulty of Part 3 questions based on the student's perceived level
- Pausing to offer encouragement beyond the standard neutral prompts

2.3 The Difference Between Supporting Learning and Collecting Performance Evidence

In the classroom, a teacher's primary obligation is to the student's development. The teacher scaffolds tasks, provides models, gives feedback, and adjusts to the learner's needs in real time. This is appropriate, necessary, and educationally sound.

In an assessment context, the teacher's primary obligation shifts dramatically. The teacher is no longer a co-participant in the student's language development. The teacher is a professional observer whose role is to elicit language from the student — through standardized questions and prompts — and to record evidence of the student's independent language ability. The teacher must not contribute to the student's performance; the teacher must document it.

This distinction — between supporting development and collecting evidence — is the conceptual foundation of examiner behavior. Everything else in this handbook follows from it.

DEFINITION: Elicitation

The use of standardized questions and prompts to draw out language from a candidate without providing assistance, guidance, or evaluative feedback that might influence the nature or quality of the response.

2.4 Maintaining Professionalism: Calm, Neutral, and Controlled

The professional demeanor of the examiner must remain stable throughout the test, regardless of whether the student is performing very well, very poorly, or unexpectedly. This stability communicates to the student that the examiner is trustworthy and impartial — that the examiner will not change the conditions of the test based on how things are going.

This stability is difficult to achieve without practice, because it runs counter to the teacher's natural empathic responsiveness. Teachers are trained to read students and respond accordingly. As examiners, they must read students — carefully — but respond consistently, regardless of what they observe.

Key markers of professional composure during the test include:

- A consistent, measured pace of speech — neither hurried nor deliberately slow
- A steady facial expression — engaged and attentive, but not expressive of evaluation
- Predictable transitions between questions and parts of the test
- Note-taking behavior that is matter-of-fact and unalarming
- Calm responses to unexpected situations, including emotional reactions from the student

2.5 Why Over-Helping Invalidates the Mock Test

Over-helping takes many forms, and teachers often engage in it without realizing they are doing so. Subtle forms of over-helping include re-reading a question more slowly after the first attempt, tilting the head encouragingly when the student pauses, or slightly altering the wording of a Part 3 question to make it more accessible.

Each of these interventions, however minor it seems in isolation, changes the conditions under which the candidate performs. They artificially elevate the student's output. If the student then performs at that artificially elevated level, the teacher's scoring will overestimate genuine proficiency.

More significantly, over-helping deprives the student of the opportunity to experience the genuine difficulty of the real test. Students who have been consistently over-helped in mock tests are often deeply shocked by the experience of the real IELTS Speaking examination — where a real examiner offers no such support. The pedagogically motivated kindness of the mock examiner becomes a disservice to the student's genuine test preparation.

2.6 Balancing Warmth with Neutrality

Neutrality does not mean coldness. The IELTS examiner handbook itself describes the examiner's demeanor as professional and friendly, not robotic or distant. The goal is to create a calm, safe environment in which the student can perform to the best of their independent ability. This requires genuine warmth in the opening interaction, a steady and attentive presence throughout, and composed, professional closure at the end.

The distinction between warmth and bias is important: the teacher should be equally warm toward every student, regardless of the student's English level, personality, nationality, or prior relationship with the teacher. Warmth that is selectively distributed — kinder toward nervous students, more distant toward confident ones — is itself a form of bias.

DEFINITION: Neutral Support

The provision of a calm, safe, and attentive testing environment through consistent professional behavior, without offering any assistance, guidance, or evaluative feedback that could influence the candidate's language output.

DEFINITION: Non-Leading Behavior

Examiner conduct that neither suggests expected answers, nor steers the candidate toward more elaborate, more correct, or more acceptable responses. This includes neutral body language, standardized prompts, and the avoidance of any verbal or non-verbal signals that indicate evaluative judgment.

2.7 What Kinds of Assistance Are Inappropriate During the Test

The following forms of assistance are inappropriate during a mock speaking test and must be actively avoided:

Type of Assistance	Example	Why It Is Inappropriate
Vocabulary provision	"The word you're looking for might be 'infrastructure'."	Supplies lexical resource the candidate does not have independently
Question simplification	"In other words, I mean... do you think it's good or bad?"	Reduces the cognitive demand of the original question
Grammatical correction	"You mean 'I have lived', right?"	Provides grammatical resource the candidate lacks
Evaluative praise	"That's a really good answer!"	Signals that a response is of high quality, possibly altering subsequent confidence
Idea provision	"For example, you could talk about transport or housing."	Supplies content the candidate should be generating independently
Extended repetition	Reading the question slowly multiple times	Gives additional processing time not available in the real test
Non-verbal approval	Strong nod, thumbs up, wide smile at correct language	Communicates evaluative judgment without words

2.8 After the Test: Returning to the Teacher Role

The teacher's role as examiner ends the moment the test concludes. At that point — and only at that point — the teacher may begin transitioning back to their pedagogical role. The shift should be deliberate and clearly signaled to the student, who will have been under assessment conditions and may need reassurance that the formal part of the interaction is now complete.

The post-test phase is covered in detail in Chapter 9. The key principle is that no feedback — not even a neutral summary of performance — should be given while the test is technically still in progress. This is particularly relevant if the teacher intends to score the test immediately after the session: scoring should be completed before the debrief conversation begins.

REFLECTION & DISCUSSION QUESTIONS
1. Identify three specific moments from your own classroom teaching practice that would be inappropriate in an examiner role. What would you do differently in each case?
2. How would you explain the concept of 'examiner mode' to a colleague who has never thought about the distinction between teaching and assessing?
3. What mechanisms might you develop to remind yourself to stay in examiner mode during the test?
4. A student you have taught for six months begins to cry during Part 2. What is the appropriate examiner response? How does this differ from your teaching response?

KEY TAKEAWAYS
• The teacher's role shifts fundamentally before, during, and after the mock test.
• During the test, the teacher is an evidence collector, not a learning supporter.
• Over-helping invalidates the mock test and deprives students of genuine preparation.
• Neutral support creates a safe testing environment without influencing language output.
• Warmth must be equally distributed to all students and must never shade into bias.
• No evaluative feedback should be given until after the test is fully complete and scored.

CHAPTER 3

Professional Demeanor During the Test

3.1 Tone of Voice

The examiner's tone of voice must be consistently calm, clear, and professionally warm. It should convey attentiveness and engagement without communicating enthusiasm for particular answers. The examiner speaks clearly and at a natural pace — not artificially slowly to aid comprehension, and not quickly in a way that adds pressure.

Teachers frequently make the mistake of adopting a noticeably different tone when a student's answer is strong versus when it is weak — speaking more animatedly after a good response, or falling into a flatter tone after a poor one. This inadvertently provides real-time feedback that the student can decode, affecting their subsequent performance.

The guiding principle is vocal consistency: the same engaged, professional tone from the opening greeting to the closing of the session.

3.2 Pacing and Timing

The examiner's pacing has two dimensions: the pace of their own speech and the timing of the test itself. Both require discipline.

In terms of speech pace, the examiner should model natural, fluent English at a conversational speed. They should not slow down for students who appear to struggle with comprehension, as this is a form of assistance that is not available in the real test. If a question needs to be repeated, it should be repeated at the same pace and in the same wording as the original.

In terms of test timing, the examiner must adhere strictly to the time allocations for each part of the test. Part 1 runs for approximately four to five minutes. Part 2 allows one minute of preparation and one to two minutes of candidate speaking. Part 3 runs for four to five minutes. Teachers frequently extend time when students are performing well and cut it short when students are struggling — both of which are unfair to the candidate and to the scoring process.

3.3 Pronunciation and Clarity of Examiner Speech

The examiner must speak with clarity and precision. Mumbled, rushed, or slurred questions create comprehension difficulties that are the examiner's fault rather than the candidate's, and they unfairly disadvantage the student. At the same time, the examiner should not artificially over-articulate or hyper-correct their own speech, as this creates an unnatural register.

Teachers who are non-native speakers of English should be particularly mindful of this dimension. Strong L1 accents in the examiner's speech can occasionally affect a student's ability to process questions, and teachers should be aware of any features of their own pronunciation that may pose comprehension challenges.

3.4 Facial Expression and Body Language

The examiner's face is a powerful communication tool, and it must be managed with care. The key principle is neutrality without blankness. The examiner should maintain a composed, attentive, interested expression — the expression of a person who is genuinely listening — without communicating any evaluative response to the student's answers.

Specific behaviors to monitor include:

- Excessive nodding in agreement, which signals approval
- Raised eyebrows in response to errors, which signals surprise or disapproval
- Wide smiles or expressions of delight when a student uses impressive vocabulary
- Subtle frowning when a student makes repeated errors
- Looking away or at notes when a student is speaking — this can feel dismissive

The examiner's posture should be upright and engaged. Leaning forward slightly conveys attentiveness. Leaning back may be read by the student as distance or boredom. Crossed arms may signal defensiveness or judgment. A neutral, open posture is most appropriate.

3.5 Eye Contact

Consistent, appropriate eye contact is one of the most important professional behaviors the examiner must develop. The examiner should maintain eye contact with the student while speaking and while the student is speaking. This communicates attentiveness and respect, and it ensures the student feels heard.

However, during note-taking — particularly during Part 2 when the student is delivering a monologue — the examiner will necessarily look at their notes. This is acceptable, but the examiner should periodically return eye contact to the student to maintain the sense of an engaged audience.

Sustained avoidance of eye contact during the student's response can make the student feel their answer is being ignored, which may cause them to stop or rush. Conversely, intense, unblinking eye contact can feel evaluative or intimidating.

3.6 Attentiveness and Note-Taking

The examiner must give the impression — and the reality — of genuine, focused listening throughout the test. Students who feel they are not being listened to often stop elaborating, reduce their response length, or lose confidence. Attentive listening is a form of professional courtesy that serves both the student's performance and the quality of the assessment data.

Note-taking should be unobtrusive and non-alarming. The student should not be able to read the examiner's notes, and the notes should not be so conspicuous that they cause the student to become self-conscious or anxious. Notes should be organized by band descriptor and written during natural pauses in the test, not frantically scribbled in real time. More guidance on scoring notes appears in Chapter 8.

3.7 The Examiner's Presence and Its Influence on Candidate Performance

How the Examiner's Presence Influences Candidate Performance

Research in oral assessment consistently demonstrates that candidate performance in speaking tests is significantly affected by the behavior, demeanor, and perceived attitudes of the examiner. Key findings include:

- Candidates perform better when they perceive the examiner as warm and non-judgmental
- Candidates produce longer and more elaborate turns when the examiner displays consistent attentiveness
- Candidates become anxious and produce shorter turns when they detect boredom or negative evaluation in the examiner's non-verbal behavior
- Candidates who have a prior relationship with the examiner tend to relax faster and perform more comfortably, which can either accurately reflect or artificially elevate their true proficiency

The practical implication of this research for teachers conducting mock tests is clear: the examiner's behavior is not neutral. It is always influencing the candidate. The goal is to ensure that this influence is positive and standardized — creating a safe, calm environment — rather than inadvertently positive for some students and inadvertently negative for others.

3.8 Examples of Appropriate and Inappropriate Examiner Behavior

Situation	Appropriate Examiner Behavior	Inappropriate Examiner Behavior
Student gives an impressive answer	Neutral nod, proceed to next question	"Wow, that's excellent! Great vocabulary!"
Student gives a very short answer	Use standard prompt: "Can you tell me more about that?"	"Is that all? Can you try to say more this time?"
Student pauses for a long time	Wait patiently; if necessary: "Take your time"	"Don't worry, it's okay. What about..." (switching topic too quickly)
Student makes a grammar error	Note it silently; continue	"Actually, the correct form is 'have gone' — try again"

Student uses excellent vocabulary	Maintain neutral expression; note it	Lean forward, smile broadly, say "Ooh, nice word!"
Student appears very nervous	Maintain warm, calm tone; do not alter test conditions	Reassure excessively; simplify next question to reduce pressure
Student goes off-topic	Allow to complete thought; re-direct with standard prompt	Interrupt: "I think you misunderstood — let me re-explain"

REFLECTION & DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Record yourself conducting a mock speaking test (with permission). Review your body language, tone, and facial expressions. What do you notice?

2. Which aspect of examiner demeanor do you find most difficult to control — facial expression, tone of voice, or pacing? Why?

3. How would you explain to a student why the examiner does not react expressively to their answers?

4. What strategies might you use to maintain consistent eye contact while also taking notes?

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Tone, pacing, body language, and eye contact must all be deliberately managed during the mock test.
- The examiner should be consistently warm but consistently neutral — never evaluative.
- Note-taking should be unobtrusive and organized by band descriptor.
- The examiner's presence is never neutral — it always influences the candidate. The goal is to ensure that influence is consistent and professionally supportive.
- All examiner behaviors that communicate evaluation — verbal or non-verbal — must be controlled.

CHAPTER 4

Standard Test Flow and Administration

4.1 Room Setup and Environment Preparation

Physical Mock Tests

The testing environment should be quiet, private, and free from interruptions. Ideally, the session takes place in a room separate from other students and from classroom noise. The teacher and student should be seated at a table, facing each other at a comfortable distance — close enough for natural conversation, but not so close as to feel intrusive. Recording devices, if used with the student's consent, should be positioned unobtrusively.

The teacher should ensure the following before the student enters:

- A stopwatch or timing device is ready and visible to the teacher
- The Part 2 task card is face-down on the table or in the teacher's possession
- A notepad and pen for scoring notes are ready
- No teaching materials, textbooks, or corrective resources are visible
- Mobile phones and other devices belonging to the teacher are silenced

Online Mock Tests

Online mock tests require additional preparation. The teacher should:

- Test the video connection, microphone, and audio at least five minutes before the session
- Ensure adequate lighting so the student can see the teacher's face clearly
- Position the camera at eye level to simulate natural face-to-face interaction
- Have a backup communication plan in case of connection failure
- Prepare to display the Part 2 task card digitally — either via a prepared image or by reading it aloud clearly

4.2 Opening the Session

The opening of the mock test is critical. It sets the tone for the entire interaction and signals to the student that the formal assessment has begun. The teacher should open with a brief, warm, professional greeting — not a casual conversation opener — and immediately transition into the formal beginning of the test.

SAMPLE EXAMINER LANGUAGE
Good morning / Good afternoon. My name is [Name], and I'll be conducting your IELTS Speaking practice test today.
In this session, we will be doing all three parts of the IELTS Speaking test. I will be asking you questions, and you should answer as fully as you can.
First, I'd like to confirm your name. Could you tell me your full name, please?
(After student responds:) Thank you. Let's begin with Part One.

TRAINER NOTE
The teacher should avoid lengthy explanations of the test format during the opening. The student should already know the test structure from their preparation. If a student appears genuinely confused, a brief one-sentence orientation is acceptable, but teachers should resist the urge to use the opening as a teaching moment.

4.3 Part 1: Introductory Questions

Purpose

Part 1 is designed to help the candidate relax and begin speaking on familiar, comfortable topics related to their personal life and everyday experiences. It assesses the candidate's ability to respond to direct questions fluently and coherently. The topics at this stage are deliberately accessible — home, family, work, study, hobbies, daily routines, and other personal preferences.

Timing

Part 1 runs for approximately four to five minutes. The examiner typically covers two or three topic areas with multiple questions per topic. The teacher should monitor timing carefully and ensure that no single topic consumes the entire Part 1 allocation.

Style of Questioning

Questions in Part 1 are direct and relatively concrete. They invite personal responses: 'Do you enjoy cooking?' / 'What kind of music do you listen to?' / 'Tell me about where you live.' Follow-up questions within a topic area are acceptable and standard, but they must be genuinely neutral — designed to elicit more language, not to guide the student toward a better answer.

Appropriate Follow-Ups

The number of follow-up questions within a single topic should be reasonable — typically two to four — before transitioning to a new topic or moving to Part 2. The following are examples of acceptable follow-up prompts:

SAMPLE EXAMINER LANGUAGE
Can you tell me a little more about that?
Why is that?
How long have you been doing that?
Do you think that will change in the future?
Is that common where you live?

✓ DO	✗ DO NOT
Allow the student to respond fully before asking the next question	Ask leading follow-ups that suggest the expected answer
Use the standard prompt 'Can you tell me more about that?' if the answer is too short	Repeatedly ask the same question in simpler wording
Move on naturally when the student has fully addressed a question	Stay on one topic for the entire Part 1 because the student is enjoying it
Keep your follow-up questions genuine and neutral	Comment evaluatively on the student's answers
Move to Part 2 promptly when the allotted time is reached	Allow Part 1 to run beyond five minutes

4.4 Part 2: Individual Long Turn

Purpose

Part 2 assesses the candidate's ability to speak at length on a given topic with minimal prompting from the examiner. It is the most individually revealing part of the test in terms of fluency, vocabulary range, and organizational ability. The candidate is given a task card describing a topic and several guiding bullet points, is allowed one minute to prepare, and must then speak for one to two minutes.

Giving the Task Card

The examiner should hand the task card to the student clearly and calmly, along with a pencil and paper for notes. The student should be explicitly told that they have one minute to prepare.

SAMPLE EXAMINER LANGUAGE
Now I'm going to give you a topic, and I'd like you to talk about it for one to two minutes. Before you speak, you'll have one minute to think about what you want to say. You can make notes if you wish.
Here is your topic. (Hand card to student.) I'd like you to talk about [topic]. You have one minute to prepare. (Begin timing.)

Managing the One-Minute Preparation

During the preparation minute, the examiner should sit quietly and allow the student to think and make notes. The examiner should not make conversation, offer suggestions, or respond to questions about the topic. If the student asks for help understanding the topic card, the examiner may read any part of it aloud, but should not explain or expand upon it.

After exactly one minute, the teacher should prompt the student to begin:

SAMPLE EXAMINER LANGUAGE
Alright, please go ahead now.
Thank you, you can begin now.

During the Long Turn

The examiner should listen attentively and take notes. The student should speak for between one and two minutes. If the student finishes in under one minute, the examiner may use a standard prompt to elicit more:

SAMPLE EXAMINER LANGUAGE
Thank you. Can you tell me a little more about that?
Is there anything else you would like to add?

If the student is still speaking at the two-minute mark, the examiner should interrupt politely and decisively:

SAMPLE EXAMINER LANGUAGE
Thank you. I'd now like to ask you one or two questions about the topic.
Thank you, that's great. Let me ask you a quick follow-up question.

Part 2 Follow-Up Questions

After the long turn, the examiner may ask one or two brief follow-up questions related to the topic card. These should be concrete questions that invite a short response, not open-ended abstract questions (which are reserved for Part 3).

4.5 Part 3: Two-Way Discussion

Purpose

Part 3 is the most cognitively demanding section of the IELTS Speaking test. It moves from personal topics into more abstract, societal-level discussion. The examiner asks questions that invite the candidate to speculate, analyze, compare, and develop extended arguments. The topics are thematically connected to the Part 2 card but require a higher level of abstract thinking and language precision.

Style of Questioning

Part 3 questions are open-ended and require extended, thoughtful responses. They may include questions such as:

- 'In your opinion, why is [topic] becoming increasingly important?'
- 'How do you think [topic] will change in the future?'
- 'Some people argue that... What do you think?'
- 'What are the advantages and disadvantages of...?'

Neutral Probing

The examiner may follow up on a candidate's answer to probe further or clarify. This probing must be neutral — it must not suggest that the candidate's initial response was insufficient, incorrect, or incomplete in a negative sense. It is simply an invitation to develop the answer further.

SAMPLE EXAMINER LANGUAGE
That's interesting. Could you develop that idea a bit more?
Why do you think that is the case?
What about from a different perspective?
Some people would argue the opposite. What would you say to them?
Can you give me an example?

Avoiding the Debate or Lesson

Part 3 carries the risk of slipping into a debate or an informal lesson if the teacher is not careful. The teacher must not express their own opinions in a way that invites the student to agree or disagree with the teacher (rather than the question). The teacher must not correct factual information or language during Part 3. The teacher must not simplify abstract questions into concrete ones because the student appears to be struggling.

✓ DO	✗ DO NOT
Ask abstract questions in their intended form	Share your personal opinion in a way that positions the student as agreeing or disagreeing with you
Probe neutrally to elicit more developed responses	Simplify abstract questions into concrete personal ones
Move between questions at an appropriate pace	Turn the discussion into a debate in which the teacher argues a position
Accept and acknowledge responses without evaluating them	Provide content scaffolding when the student cannot think of ideas
End Part 3 decisively when time is reached	Allow Part 3 to run beyond five minutes

4.6 Closing the Test

The closing of the test should be brief, warm, and clearly signal the end of the formal assessment. The teacher should not give any evaluative feedback — not even a general positive comment — at this stage.

SAMPLE EXAMINER LANGUAGE
Thank you very much. That brings us to the end of the speaking test.
Thank you. That's everything I need.
That concludes our session today. I'll have some feedback for you shortly.

TRAINER NOTE
Remind teachers that 'That was great!' or 'Well done!' after the test — even if said casually — gives the student evaluative information that may not be accurate and may affect how they receive the feedback session. End on a warm, neutral note.

4.7 Timing Summary

Part	Activity	Approximate Duration
Opening	Greeting, name confirmation, orientation	1 minute
Part 1	Two to three topic areas with questions	4 to 5 minutes
Transition	Introduction of Part 2 instructions	30 seconds
Part 2	Task card + 1-minute preparation + 1-2 min speaking + brief follow-up	3 to 4 minutes
Part 3	Abstract discussion on related theme	4 to 5 minutes
Closing	End of test statement	30 seconds
Total		Approximately 14 to 17 minutes

REFLECTION & DISCUSSION QUESTIONS
1. Practise delivering the opening script with a colleague. How does it feel? What feels unnatural and why?
2. Role-play a Part 2 administration. How do you manage the transition from preparation to speaking? What happens when the student finishes too early?
3. Which part of the test do you find most difficult to standardize? Why?
4. How would you manage a transition from Part 2 to Part 3 if the student is in the middle of an enthusiastic response?

KEY TAKEAWAYS
• Every phase of the test — from setup to closing — requires deliberate preparation and professional discipline.
• Part 1 is conversational and accessible; Part 2 is an extended monologue; Part 3 is abstract and challenging.
• Timing discipline is an assessment fairness requirement — not a preference.
• Standard examiner language should be prepared and practised, not improvised in the moment.
• The examiner should never provide evaluative comment before the test is fully over and scored.

CHAPTER 5

What Teachers Should Say and Should Never Say

5.1 The Principle of Neutral Examiner Language

Examiner language must serve one function only during the test: to elicit language from the candidate. Every word the examiner speaks must be either a question that requires a response, a standard prompt that invites elaboration, or a transition that moves the test forward. No examiner utterance should communicate evaluation, opinion, correction, or guidance.

This section catalogs the language that is appropriate and the language that must be avoided, with explanations for each.

5.2 Acceptable Functional Language

Opening Language

SAMPLE EXAMINER LANGUAGE
Good morning. My name is [Name], and I'll be conducting your IELTS Speaking practice test.
Could you tell me your full name, please?
Thank you. Let's begin with Part One.

Standard Question Prompts (Part 1)

SAMPLE EXAMINER LANGUAGE
Let me ask you about [topic].
Do you [enjoy / prefer / often / usually]...?
Tell me about a time when...
What do you think about...?
How long have you been...?

Why do you think that is?
Is that something most people in your country / area would agree with?

Neutral Follow-Up Prompts (All Parts)

SAMPLE EXAMINER LANGUAGE
Can you tell me a little more about that?
Why is that?
Could you give me an example?
Is there anything else you would like to add?

Repetition Language

SAMPLE EXAMINER LANGUAGE
I'll repeat the question. (Read question again at the same pace.)
Certainly. (Repeat.)

Transition Language

SAMPLE EXAMINER LANGUAGE
Thank you. Let's move on to another topic.
Now I'd like to ask you about a different subject.
Right. Now I'm going to give you a topic and I'd like you to speak about it for one to two minutes.
Thank you. Now I'd like to discuss some more general questions related to that topic.

Managing Silence

Silence during the test should generally be tolerated. Students need processing time, and premature prompting deprives them of the opportunity to demonstrate language retrieval. However, after an extended silence — typically five to eight seconds — the examiner may offer:

SAMPLE EXAMINER LANGUAGE
Take your time.
Shall I repeat the question?

Brief Reassurance Language (Non-Evaluative)

These phrases communicate attentiveness without conveying approval:

SAMPLE EXAMINER LANGUAGE
I see.
Right.
Thank you.
I understand.
Okay.

5.3 Language That Must Be Avoided

The following table presents examples of language that is inappropriate during the mock test, with explanations for why each is problematic.

Category	Bad Example	Why It Is Problematic
Praise	"That's a brilliant answer!"	Signals to the student that their response is of high quality, which may inflate confidence and affect subsequent performance
Praise (subtle)	"Yes, exactly right!"	Confirms the student answered correctly, providing evaluative information they should not receive during the test
Corrective feedback	"Actually, it should be 'I have been' not 'I was'."	Provides grammatical instruction during assessment, invalidating the test
Leading question	"Don't you think technology has made life better overall?"	Suggests the expected or preferred answer, biasing the student's response

Reformulating the question	"What I mean is — do you think it's a good thing or a bad thing?"	Simplifies the question, reducing its cognitive demand and artificially elevating the student's performance
Vocabulary suggestion	"Are you thinking of the word 'sustainable'?"	Provides lexical resource the student does not possess independently
Grammar prompt	"Try using 'because' or 'however' to connect your ideas."	Provides grammatical and cohesion scaffolding that should come from the student alone
Debate-style challenge	"I completely disagree — I think the opposite is true."	Transforms the assessment into a debate and may intimidate or confuse the student
Over-explaining	"Let me explain what the question means — it's asking about your opinion on..."	Adds comprehension support not available in the real test
Idea provision	"You could mention public transport, for example, or environmental issues."	Provides content scaffolding that removes the cognitive challenge the test is designed to pose

CASE SCENARIO

Situation: A student says, 'I don't know how to say it in English.' The teacher instinctively says, 'The word you're looking for is probably economy — try using that.'

What to notice: The student is demonstrating a real gap in their lexical resource. This is exactly what the Lexical Resource criterion is measuring.

Appropriate response: Say nothing, or use the neutral prompt: 'Try to explain it in another way if you can.'

What to avoid: Do not provide the vocabulary. The student's struggle is assessment data.

CASE SCENARIO

Situation: After the student gives an excellent Part 3 response, the teacher says: 'Great! That was very well-developed. Now let me ask you...'

What to notice: The teacher has given direct evaluative praise mid-test, which inflates the student's confidence and signals that their answer met a high standard.

Appropriate response: Respond with a neutral 'Thank you' or 'I see' and transition to the next question.

What to avoid: Avoid any word — 'great', 'perfect', 'exactly', 'brilliant' — that conveys positive evaluation.

5.4 A Note on 'Thank You'

The phrase 'Thank you' is widely used by IELTS examiners as a transition marker. It does not express evaluative gratitude — it simply signals that the examiner has received the student's response and is ready to move on. Teachers should use it consistently in this way, without varying their intonation to communicate more warmth after good answers or less warmth after weak ones.

'Thank you' spoken with a bright, rising intonation after an excellent answer is not neutral. It communicates approval. 'Thank you' spoken in a flat, slightly rushed tone after a weak answer also communicates evaluation. The goal is a consistent, medium-warm, forward-moving 'Thank you' after every response.

REFLECTION & DISCUSSION QUESTIONS
1. Record five phrases you habitually use in class to praise students. For each one, identify what the neutral examiner equivalent would be.
2. How would you handle a student who directly asks you, 'Was that a good answer?'
3. Role-play a Part 3 exchange in which one teacher plays the examiner and the other deliberately gives a very weak answer. Notice how the 'examiner' instinctively responds.
4. Draft your own list of five transition phrases you feel comfortable using. Practise them until they sound natural in a formal context.

KEY TAKEAWAYS
• Examiner language has one purpose: to elicit candidate language without influencing it.
• Praise, correction, vocabulary suggestion, question simplification, and idea provision are all forms of assistance that must be eliminated.
• Standard examiner phrases should be practised until they feel natural.
• Even small words like 'Thank you' carry evaluative meaning if the intonation is inconsistent — tone management matters at every moment.

CHAPTER 6

Handling Problems and Unexpected Situations

Even the most carefully prepared mock test will occasionally encounter unexpected situations. How the teacher-examiner responds to these moments is critically important. This chapter provides detailed protocols for the most common incident types encountered in mock speaking test administration.

6.1 General Principles for Incident Management

Regardless of the specific situation, three overarching principles apply to all unexpected events during the mock test:

1. Remain calm. Any visible anxiety or confusion in the examiner immediately increases the candidate's anxiety.
2. Use standard language. Do not improvise reassurance that involves evaluation. Return to standardized prompts wherever possible.
3. Document and assess separately. The incident may affect the student's performance, but note-taking should continue. The scoring rationale for an incident-affected response should be noted explicitly.

6.2 Situation Protocols

6.2.1 The Candidate Becomes Emotional or Begins to Cry

Protocol Element	Guidance
What to notice	Tears, shaking voice, loss of composure. Distinguish between brief emotional distress and genuine inability to continue.
Immediate response	Pause the test quietly. Offer a moment of composure. Do not ignore it or push through.
What to say	"Take a moment if you need to. There is no rush." or "It's okay. Would you like a moment?"
What to avoid	Do not say 'Don't worry, you're doing so well!' — this is evaluative. Do not adjust subsequent questions to be easier.
Fairness	If the student recovers and continues, score based on the language produced. Note the emotional incident in scoring notes as context.

Scoring	Brief emotional disruption should not lower the band score for Fluency. Extended inability to speak may require the test to be rescheduled.

6.2.2 The Candidate Freezes or Goes Silent

Protocol Element	Guidance
What to notice	Extended silence beyond 8–10 seconds with no attempt to begin speaking.
Immediate response	Wait an additional 5 seconds. Then offer the standard prompt.
What to say	"Take your time." or "Shall I repeat the question?" (Repeat at same pace and wording.)
What to avoid	Do not re-explain the question. Do not suggest content. Do not say 'Don't worry about it — just say anything.'
Fairness	If the candidate cannot produce language after a reasonable wait and one repetition, move to the next question. Note the silence.
Scoring	Extended silence on specific questions lowers Fluency and Coherence scores for those moments. It does not retroactively affect scores on other questions.

6.2.3 Candidate Says 'I Don't Understand'

Protocol Element	Guidance
What to notice	Distinguish between a request for repetition (they heard the question but need more time) and genuine comprehension difficulty.
Immediate response	Offer to repeat the question once, at the same pace and in the same wording.
What to say	"Certainly. I'll repeat the question. (Repeat.)"
What to avoid	Do not paraphrase, simplify, or explain the question. Do not offer examples of what a good answer might cover.
Fairness	If a candidate repeatedly requests repetition, this is itself assessment data — it may reflect difficulty with the examiner's pronunciation or with listening comprehension.
Scoring	Repeated requests for repetition are noted. They may affect the coherence of responses but should not be misread as Fluency issues.

6.2.4 Candidate Speaks Off-Topic

Protocol Element	Guidance
What to notice	The response is clearly unrelated to the question asked. Distinguish between slight tangential development (acceptable) and complete topic deviation.
Immediate response	Allow the response to complete naturally if it is brief. Then re-direct with a standard prompt.
What to say	"Thank you. I'd like to come back to the original question. (Repeat question.)"
What to avoid	Do not interrupt mid-response to redirect unless the tangent is very long. Do not express frustration or confusion.
Fairness	Off-topic responses are assessment data. They are relevant to Coherence scoring.
Scoring	Note the off-topic response explicitly. Assess coherence on the basis of the response actually given.

6.2.5 Candidate Gives Very Short Answers

Protocol Element	Guidance
What to notice	Responses of one or two words, or one very brief sentence, when a more extended response is expected.
Immediate response	Use a standard follow-up prompt once.
What to say	"Can you tell me more about that?" or "Why do you think that is?"
What to avoid	Do not use prompts that suggest the expected content (e.g., 'What about the reasons? Or the effects?'). Do not use more than one or two follow-up prompts — excessive prompting is also a form of assistance.
Fairness	Short answers are assessment data. A student who consistently provides minimal responses is demonstrating a limitation that should be reflected in the score.
Scoring	Short answers affect Fluency, Coherence, and potentially Lexical and Grammatical Range. Note the pattern.

6.2.6 Candidate Asks 'Is My Answer Okay?'

Protocol Element	Guidance
What to notice	The student is seeking evaluative reassurance during the test — a clear sign of anxiety.
Immediate response	Respond with a warm but non-evaluative statement.
What to say	"I can't comment on your answers during the test. Let's continue." or "All answers are fine — just continue."
What to avoid	Do not say 'Yes, that was good!' or 'Don't worry, you're doing fine.' These are evaluative and inaccurate.
Fairness	The question itself should not be penalized. Acknowledge it briefly and move on.
Scoring	The anxiety is noted. It does not affect scores unless it produces disfluency in subsequent responses.

6.2.7 Candidate Uses Memorized Responses

Protocol Element	Guidance
What to notice	Rehearsed-sounding, highly fluent, uncharacteristically formal answers that do not directly address the specific question asked. Abrupt decline in quality after the rehearsed portion ends.
Immediate response	Continue the test. Ask follow-up questions that deviate from the anticipated topic path.
What to say	Use a follow-up that requires the student to respond to the specific context: "Thank you. And in your particular experience — not generally, but your own — what would you say?"
What to avoid	Do not accuse the student of memorizing. Do not make the situation feel confrontational.
Fairness	Memorized responses that are fluent and coherent still generate some performance data. The decline in quality when unscripted territory is reached is also assessment data.
Scoring	Assess the language produced across the full test. Note the discrepancy between scripted and unscripted performance.

6.2.8 Candidate Panics in Part 2

Protocol Element	Guidance
What to notice	Visible anxiety, inability to start speaking after the preparation minute, very short responses, or explicit statements of distress ('I don't know what to say').
Immediate response	Remain calm and use a gentle but non-evaluative prompt.
What to say	"Take your time. You can start with any of the points on the card." or "Just begin wherever feels comfortable."
What to avoid	Do not offer content guidance. Do not reassure with evaluative language. Do not extend the preparation time significantly beyond one minute.
Fairness	Anxiety is not a language deficiency. However, it may produce disfluency that affects Fluency scores. Note this in scoring rationale.
Scoring	If panic severely limits the Part 2 response, the overall band estimate should account for the fact that Part 2 data is reduced, and weight the remaining test evidence accordingly.

6.2.9 Online Connection or Audio Problems

Protocol Element	Guidance
What to notice	Frozen screen, audio lag, microphone failure, connection drops.
Immediate response	Pause the timer immediately. Attempt to re-establish connection. Do not score the affected portion.
What to say	"We appear to be having a technical issue. I'll pause the test for a moment."
What to avoid	Do not continue scoring while the connection is unstable. Do not attempt to continue through poor audio.
Fairness	If connection issues are brief and isolated, the test may continue from the point of disruption. If sustained, the test should be rescheduled.
Scoring	Note the disruption and its duration. Do not penalize the student for technical failures outside their control.

COMMON MISTAKES TO AVOID
Giving verbal reassurance mid-test that includes evaluative language (e.g., 'Don't worry — you're actually doing very well!').
Adjusting the difficulty of subsequent questions because the student appears to be struggling — this is interference, not fairness.
Penalizing a student's Fluency score because they were briefly emotional, when the disruption was brief and recovery was complete.
Accusing a student of memorization directly rather than addressing it through varied follow-up questions.
Continuing the test through significant technical problems and then scoring the affected portion.

REFLECTION & DISCUSSION QUESTIONS
1. A student cries briefly in Part 1 but recovers and continues. How do you handle the next few minutes of the test? What do you score?
2. You suspect a student has memorized a response in Part 2. How do you verify this through your questioning? What do you do with the evidence?
3. A student asks you, mid-Part 3, to explain what 'socioeconomic' means. How do you respond?
4. How do you distinguish between a student whose disfluency reflects anxiety and a student whose disfluency reflects genuine Fluency limitations?

KEY TAKEAWAYS
• Remain calm in all unexpected situations — the examiner's composure directly regulates the candidate's anxiety.
• Standard language is always preferred over improvised reassurance during incidents.
• Emotional distress is not automatically evidence of language deficiency — it should be noted but not penalized unless it produces measurable impact on language performance.
• Every incident should be documented in scoring notes with contextual explanation.
• Fairness toward the candidate means maintaining consistent conditions, not eliminating difficulty.

CHAPTER 7

Scoring the IELTS Speaking Test Properly

Accurate scoring is the ultimate purpose of the mock test. Everything discussed in the preceding chapters — professional demeanor, standardized administration, appropriate language — exists to ensure that the scoring process yields a valid, reliable band estimate. This chapter provides a detailed reference guide for assessing each of the four IELTS Speaking band descriptors.

All band descriptor descriptions and examples in this chapter are drawn from the official IELTS scoring framework and the JIC Band Descriptor Reference Document.

7.1 Fluency and Coherence

DEFINITION: Fluency

The smoothness and continuity of speech — how naturally and uninterruptedly the candidate speaks without excessive pausing, hesitation, or self-repair.

DEFINITION: Coherence

The logical organization and connection of ideas — whether the candidate's sentences and thoughts flow logically and clearly so that the listener can follow the argument or narrative.

What Teachers Should Listen For — Fluency

Key fluency indicators teachers should assess during the mock test include:

- Speech rate: Is the rate natural and consistent? Not so slow that it disrupts comprehension, not so fast that accuracy deteriorates.
- Hesitations: Are pauses natural (associated with content selection at Band 7-9) or unnatural (associated with word and grammar search at Band 4-6)?
- False starts: Does the student begin, abandon, and restart sentences frequently in a way that disrupts flow?
- Self-correction: Is self-correction occasional and smooth (positive sign), or so frequent that it significantly disrupts delivery?
- Repetition: Does the student repeat words and phrases to buy time, or as natural topic reinforcement?

What Teachers Should Listen For — Coherence

Key coherence indicators include:

- Logical sequencing: Do ideas follow one another in a way that makes sense to the listener?
- Use of discourse markers and cohesive devices: Does the student use a range of linking language? Is it used accurately and naturally?
- Topic development: Does the student develop their ideas with reasons, examples, and elaboration, or produce list-like responses with minimal development?
- Relevance: Does the student stay on topic, or drift in ways that confuse the listener?

How to Separate Fluency from Coherence

This distinction is critical and is one of the most commonly confused aspects of scoring for teacher-examiners.

Fluency is about the physical delivery of speech: its rhythm, pace, continuity, and smoothness. A student may speak fluently — at a consistent, uninterrupted pace — but produce incoherent content: ideas that do not connect logically.

Coherence is about the intellectual organization of speech: whether ideas flow logically, are properly connected, and develop the point being made. A student may produce a coherent, well-organized argument but do so haltingly, with pauses and self-corrections.

In practice, a student with strong fluency but weak coherence will sound smooth but rambling or confused. A student with strong coherence but weak fluency will sound hesitant but ultimately logical and clear.

Scenario	Fluency Assessment	Coherence Assessment
Student speaks smoothly and quickly but answers drift off-topic repeatedly	High (delivery is uninterrupted)	Low (logical organization is poor)
Student hesitates frequently but produces well-structured, logical arguments	Lower (delivery disrupted)	High (logical structure is clear)

Student uses 'and, and, and' to connect ideas smoothly but ideas have no logical relationship	Moderate to high	Low (cohesive device range and accuracy are weak)
Student pauses mid-sentence to think of content but resumes logically	Band 7-8 characteristic	High (pause is content-related, not grammar/word-search)

Fluency and Coherence Band Descriptors — Quick Reference

Band	Fluency Characteristics	Coherence Characteristics
1-2	Essentially no connected speech; isolated words only	No coherent structure; utterances do not form logical sequences
3	Frequent, sometimes long pauses while searching for words; often cannot convey basic message	Limited ability to link simple sentences; frequently unable to communicate basic message
4	Unable to continue without noticeable pauses; slow speech with frequent repetition; often self-corrects	Can link simple sentences with repetitious connectives; some breakdowns in coherence
5	Relies on repetition and self-correction to continue; hesitates for basic lexis and grammar; overuses certain connectives	Some effective use of cohesive features but not sustained; may lose coherence when attempting more complex language
6	Able to keep going and willing to produce long turns; coherence may be lost due to hesitation and self-correction	Uses a range of discourse markers though not always appropriately; coherent in familiar topics
7	Readily produces long turns without noticeable effort; mid-sentence hesitations do not affect coherence	Flexible use of cohesive features; logical progression of ideas is intact even with minor pauses
8	Fluent with only occasional repetition or self-correction; hesitation mostly content-related	Topic development is coherent, appropriate, and relevant throughout
9	Fluent with only very occasional repetition; any hesitation is solely for content preparation, not word/grammar search	Fully coherent and appropriately extended topic development

7.2 Lexical Resource

DEFINITION: Lexical Resource
The range, accuracy, and appropriateness of the vocabulary the candidate uses, including their ability to paraphrase effectively when a specific word is unavailable.

What Teachers Should Listen For

The key dimensions of Lexical Resource that teachers must assess independently include:

- Vocabulary range: Does the student use a variety of words, or do they rely repeatedly on high-frequency basics (good, nice, bad, thing)?
- Appropriateness and style: Does the vocabulary suit the context, register, and topic? Is formal vocabulary used in formal contexts?
- Collocation accuracy: Are words combined naturally? (e.g., 'make a decision' not 'do a decision')
- Idiomatic and less common items: Are lower-frequency vocabulary items used, and used correctly?
- Paraphrase: When a word is not available, can the student explain the concept in other words effectively?

Common Teacher Misunderstandings in Lexical Scoring

COMMON MISTAKES TO AVOID
Rewarding students who use long or academic-sounding words incorrectly. Precision and appropriateness matter more than word length.
Penalizing students who use simple vocabulary correctly and appropriately. Accurate simple vocabulary at Band 5-6 should not be confused with Band 3-4 performance.
Confusing coherent topic development with strong lexical resource. A student who elaborates well but uses basic vocabulary has strong Coherence, not strong Lexical Resource.
Over-rewarding idiomatic usage that is learned by rote and used in fixed, memorized contexts rather than genuinely flexibly.

Lexical Resource Band Descriptors — Quick Reference

Band	Lexical Characteristics
1-2	No resource or very limited; isolated words; no communicative meaning
3	Simple vocabulary for personal information only; vocabulary inadequate for unfamiliar topics
4	Sufficient for familiar topics; frequent inappropriacies and errors; rarely attempts paraphrase
5	Sufficient for familiar and unfamiliar topics; limited flexibility; attempts paraphrase but not always successfully
6	Sufficient to discuss topics at length; vocabulary may be inappropriate but meaning is clear; generally able to paraphrase
7	Resource flexibly used; some ability to use less common and idiomatic items; aware of style and collocation; effective paraphrase
8	Wide resource used readily and flexibly; skilful use of less common and idiomatic items with occasional inaccuracies; effective paraphrase
9	Total flexibility and precise use in all contexts; sustained accurate and idiomatic language throughout

7.3 Grammatical Range and Accuracy

DEFINITION: Grammatical Range
The variety of sentence structures, verb forms, clause types, and grammatical constructions the candidate uses during the test.

DEFINITION: Grammatical Accuracy
The degree to which grammatical structures are used correctly and consistently, including verb tense, subject-verb agreement, article use, prepositions, and sentence construction.

What Teachers Should Listen For

Grammar assessment requires the teacher to monitor two separate dimensions simultaneously. Range is about variety; accuracy is about correctness. A student may show range — attempting complex structures — but with low accuracy. A student may show high accuracy — but only because they exclusively use simple structures, limiting their range.

- Sentence length and complexity: Does the student produce only short, simple sentences, or do they attempt longer, multi-clause structures?
- Subordinate clauses: Does the student use clauses beginning with because, although, when, which, that, if?
- Tense control: Are tenses selected appropriately and used consistently?
- Passive voice: Is the passive used when appropriate?
- Modal verbs: Are modals (might, should, could, would) used naturally and correctly?
- Error frequency and severity: How often do errors occur? Do errors cause comprehension difficulty for the listener?

How to Avoid Mixing Vocabulary, Grammar, and Pronunciation Judgments

One of the most common and consequential scoring errors teachers make is conflating the four band descriptors. A student who sounds sophisticated because of their confident pronunciation and rich vocabulary may have relatively weak grammar. A student who uses an unusually complex grammatical range but pronounces words inaccurately may sound less impressive than they actually are.

Teachers must listen for each descriptor independently. A practical method is to make a separate listening pass for each criterion during playback of a recording, rather than trying to assess all four simultaneously during the live test.

Grammatical Range and Accuracy Band Descriptors — Quick Reference

Band	Range Characteristics	Accuracy Characteristics
1-2	No sentence forms produced or attempted	No assessable language
3	Basic sentence forms attempted	Numerous errors except in memorized utterances
4	Some basic, short, error-free utterances; subordinate clauses rare; structures repetitive	Errors frequent; mostly short utterances only
5	Basic sentence forms fairly well controlled; complex structures attempted	Limited range; complex structures nearly always contain errors; frequent reformulation
6	Mix of short and complex sentences; variety of structures with limited flexibility	Errors frequent in complex structures but rarely impede communication
7	Range of structures flexibly used; both simple and complex used effectively	Error-free sentences frequent; a few basic errors persist
8	Wide range of structures, flexibly used	Majority of sentences error-free; occasional non-systematic errors
9	Structures precise and accurate at all times	Only 'mistakes' characteristic of native speaker speech — minor, non-systematic

7.4 Pronunciation

DEFINITION: Pronunciation
The use of phonological features — including individual sound production, word stress, sentence stress, intonation, and connected speech — in ways that allow the listener to understand the speaker without difficulty.

What Teachers Should Listen For

IELTS Pronunciation assessment does not reward specific accents or penalize non-native accents. The central question is intelligibility: can the listener understand the speaker without effort? Secondary questions address the sophistication of phonological feature use.

- Individual sounds (phonemes): Are specific sounds mispronounced in ways that cause confusion? (e.g., /l/ and /r/ confusion; /v/ and /b/ confusion)
- Word stress: Is stress placed on the correct syllable? (e.g., 'pho-TOgraph' vs 'PHO-to-graph')
- Sentence stress: Are content words appropriately stressed to convey meaning?
- Intonation: Does the student's voice rise and fall naturally to signal questions, statements, uncertainty, and contrast?
- Chunking and rhythm: Does the student group words into natural, meaningful units, or does speech sound robotic and word-by-word?
- Connected speech: Are sounds linked naturally in fluent speech?

Common Teacher Misunderstandings in Pronunciation Scoring

COMMON MISTAKES TO AVOID
Penalizing a student for having a regional or national accent when intelligibility is not affected. Accents are not errors.
Rewarding students who sound 'native-like' without assessing whether their pronunciation features actually aid comprehension.
Conflating confident delivery with good pronunciation. A student may speak loudly and quickly but with significant mispronunciation.
Penalizing natural self-corrections related to pronunciation — these may reflect phonological awareness, which is a strength.

Pronunciation Band Descriptors — Quick Reference

Band	Pronunciation Characteristics
1-2	Unintelligible; occasional recognizable individual words or phonemes only
3-4	Frequent mispronunciation; limited and inconsistent use of phonological features; requires listener effort
5	Some phonological features present but control is weak; mispronunciations reduce clarity; listener must work to understand
6	Range of features present; control is variable; some effective use of intonation and stress; can generally be understood without much effort
7	Good range of features generally controlled; rare mispronunciation; accent present but does not interfere with understanding
8	Wide range used flexibly to convey precise meaning; can sustain appropriate rhythm; easily understood throughout; accent has minimal effect
9	Full range used to convey precise and subtle meaning; flexible use of connected speech features sustained throughout; effortlessly understood; accent has no effect on intelligibility

7.5 Evidence-Based Judgment: Principles for Fair Scoring

How to Make Evidence-Based Judgments

Every band score assigned must be supported by specific observations drawn from the candidate's actual language output. Teachers should resist the temptation to assign a band score based on a general impression ('She seemed around a 6.5') without being able to identify specific evidence from the test that supports that estimate.

Evidence-based scoring requires:

1. Noting specific examples of strong performance for each descriptor (e.g., 'used although and despite correctly in Part 3 — Grammatical Range').
2. Noting specific examples of weak performance or error patterns (e.g., 'searched for basic vocabulary in Part 1 — Fluency / Lexical Resource').
3. Comparing the observed performance against the band descriptor language to identify the most accurate band range.
4. Checking for consistency across the test — did the performance represent a sustained level, or were there significant peaks and troughs?

How to Avoid Personal Bias

Personal bias in scoring takes many forms. The following are the most commonly documented biases in oral assessment:

Bias Type	Description	How to Guard Against It
Halo Effect	A strong impression in one dimension (e.g., excellent vocabulary) inflates scores in other dimensions	Score each descriptor separately with dedicated attention
Familiarity Bias	Students the teacher knows well tend to score higher due to unconscious accommodation	Ask: 'Would I score this the same way if I had never met this student?'
Confidence Bias	Confident-sounding students score higher than equally proficient but anxious students	Ask: 'What was the language quality, not the delivery impression?'
Content Bias	Interesting or intelligent content scores higher than accurate language used on simpler content	Remind yourself: content is not a descriptor. Score language, not ideas.
Likability Bias	Students the teacher likes personally tend to score higher	Score the language, not the person.

Why Nervous Students Should Not Be Under-Scored

Anxiety can produce disfluency, hesitation, and reduced vocabulary in ways that superficially resemble a lower band than the student's actual proficiency warrants. Teachers must be particularly careful to distinguish between anxiety-induced performance reduction and genuine language limitation.

Indicators that anxiety rather than proficiency may be suppressing performance include: significant improvement in the quality of language as the test progresses and the student relaxes; visible physical signs of anxiety (shaking hands, flushed face) alongside reasonably well-formed language; comments from the student indicating awareness of their anxiety affecting performance.

In such cases, the teacher should note the contextual factors in their scoring rationale but should ultimately score based on the language that was produced. The scoring session may be followed by a note to the student and parent or programme coordinator that the score may not fully represent the student's capability, and a second mock test may be advisable.

REFLECTION & DISCUSSION QUESTIONS
1. Take a recording of a previous mock test and score it for Fluency and Coherence separately. Can you articulate specific evidence for each score?
2. Describe an instance in which you conflated two descriptors (e.g., scored Lexical Resource higher because of confident delivery). What would you do differently?
3. How would you explain to a student why their content knowledge does not directly affect their IELTS Speaking band score?
4. What systems could you put in place to ensure you are scoring each descriptor independently rather than holistically?

KEY TAKEAWAYS
• Each band descriptor — Fluency, Coherence, Lexical Resource, Grammatical Range and Accuracy, Pronunciation — must be scored independently and on the basis of concrete evidence.
• Fluency is about the physical delivery of speech; Coherence is about its logical organization. These must not be conflated.
• All four descriptors must be assessed separately — vocabulary does not compensate for grammar, and confidence does not compensate for pronunciation.
• Personal bias in its many forms — halo effect, familiarity bias, confidence bias, content bias — must be actively guarded against.
• Nervousness should be noted but should not automatically lower band scores if the language quality is present.

CHAPTER 8

Scoring Workflow for Teachers

Understanding the band descriptors is only part of the scoring challenge. The other part is the procedural question of how and when to score during and after the mock test. This chapter provides a practical workflow for teachers.

8.1 When to Score: Live or Immediately After?

The question of whether to score during the live test or immediately after it is one that different teachers approach differently. Both approaches have merit, and the best solution for most teachers is a combination: take notes during the test, and produce the final band estimates immediately after the test concludes.

Attempting to score fully during the live test risks distributing attention between scoring and test administration — one or both will suffer. Waiting too long after the test risks score drift, where memories of specific examples fade and are replaced by general impressions.

The recommended workflow is:

1. During the test: Take brief, real-time notes organized by band descriptor (see Section 8.2).
2. Immediately after the test (within five minutes of the final question): Review notes and convert observations into band estimates.
3. Within thirty minutes: Complete the full scoring rationale with supporting evidence from the notes.

8.2 What Notes to Take During the Test

Notes taken during the test serve as the evidence base for scoring. They should capture specific instances of strong and weak performance, not general impressions. The notes need not be grammatically complete — abbreviated observations are acceptable — but they must be specific enough to be usable when scoring.

The note-taking sheet should be organized into four columns or sections, one for each band descriptor. Teachers should resist the temptation to write overall impressions in the margin ('sounds like a 6') before completing the evidence column for each descriptor.

Sample Scoring Note Template

Descriptor	Positive Evidence (Strengths)	Negative Evidence (Limitations)	Initial Band Range
Fluency & Coherence			
Lexical Resource			
Grammatical Range & Accuracy			
Pronunciation			

8.3 What Good Scoring Notes Look Like

Good scoring notes are specific, descriptor-referenced, and example-based. They use abbreviated language to capture real instances of performance rather than general characterizations.

EXAMPLE: Good Scoring Notes
Fluency & Coherence: [Strength] Spoke for 90 seconds in Part 2 without significant pause. Logical progression using 'firstly... then... finally'. [Limitation] Mid-sentence restart in Part 3 twice when attempting complex ideas. Overall: Band 6.
Lexical Resource: [Strength] Used 'infrastructure', 'sustainable', 'commute' accurately in Part 3. Effective paraphrase: 'place where old buildings are preserved — like a heritage site'. [Limitation] Relied on 'nice' and 'good' in Part 1 descriptions. Overall: Band 6.
Grammatical Range: [Strength] 'Although I prefer...', 'If the government were to...', relative clause 'the system which was introduced'. [Limitation] 'He go to school' — SV agreement error, twice. 'I have go' — tense error. Overall: Band 5.

Pronunciation: [Strength] Clear word stress; natural sentence stress on content words. [Limitation] /th/ = /d/ throughout — 'de' for 'the', 'dis' for 'this'. Minimal impact on intelligibility. Overall: Band 6.

8.4 What Weak or Unreliable Scoring Notes Look Like

EXAMPLE: Weak Scoring Notes — Not Acceptable
Fluency: Pretty good, talked a lot. Maybe a 6?
Vocabulary: Used some big words. Good vocabulary.
Grammar: Made some mistakes but mostly okay.
Pronunciation: Clear enough. Maybe 6 or 7.
Overall: I think around 6 to 6.5.

These notes are useless as evidence because they contain no specific observations. They reflect general impressions rather than descriptor-referenced evidence. They cannot be used to justify a band score to a student or colleague. They are also highly susceptible to halo effect: a generally positive impression of the student produces uniformly positive impressions across all descriptors.

8.5 Converting Observations into Band Estimates

Once the notes are complete, the teacher should compare each set of observations against the band descriptor language for that criterion. The process is as follows:

1. Read the positive evidence column for a descriptor.
2. Identify which band level the observed strengths most clearly match.
3. Read the negative evidence column. Ask: 'Do these limitations push the score below the initial estimate?'
4. Settle on a band number or consider a half-band (e.g., 'between Band 5 and Band 6 — closer to 6').
5. Repeat for all four descriptors.
6. Average the four band scores to produce an overall Speaking band estimate. (Note: IELTS rounds to the nearest 0.5.)

8.6 Comparing Impression vs. Evidence

Teachers will inevitably have an overall impression of a student's performance. This impression is not without value — it often captures something real about the student's communicative effectiveness. However, it must never be allowed to override the evidence-based assessment.

If a teacher's overall impression produces a band of 6.5, but the evidence-based scoring for each descriptor produces scores of 6, 5, 6, 6 (averaging 5.75), the evidence-based score should prevail. The impression of 6.5 likely reflects the halo effect of one strong performance area, or the influence of the student's confident manner.

The discipline of evidence-based scoring is precisely what differentiates professional assessment from impression-based grading.

8.7 Sample Scoring Rationale: Full Example

SAMPLE: Full Scoring Rationale — Candidate A
Fluency and Coherence: The candidate demonstrated a willingness to produce long turns throughout the test, particularly in Part 2 where she spoke for approximately 100 seconds with only minor mid-sentence pauses. Her use of discourse markers was fairly consistent ('firstly', 'on the other hand', 'in contrast'), though 'and' and 'because' were occasionally overused in Part 1. Coherence was generally maintained, with some loss of logical thread in Part 3 when attempting more abstract ideas. Band: 6
Lexical Resource: The candidate demonstrated a sufficient lexical resource for both familiar and unfamiliar topics. She used topic-specific vocabulary ('carbon footprint', 'renewable energy', 'infrastructure') accurately in Part 3. In Part 1, she relied heavily on 'good', 'nice', and 'like' without range. One effective paraphrase was observed in Part 2 ('the thing that holds water in a building — the pipes'). Occasional word choice errors (e.g., 'I feel relax' for 'I feel relaxed'). Band: 6
Grammatical Range and Accuracy: The candidate used a mix of simple and complex structures. Successfully used: 'Although I prefer...', 'If I could...', and relative clauses ('the city which I grew up in'). Errors included consistent subject-verb agreement problems in Part 1 ('she go', 'they was'), and tense inconsistency in Part 3 narrative. Complex structure attempts were frequent but often inaccurate. Band: 5

Pronunciation: The candidate was clearly understandable throughout. Word stress was generally appropriate; sentence stress fell naturally on content words. The /th/ sound was consistently replaced with /d/ ('dis' for 'this', 'de' for 'the'), but this did not impede intelligibility. Intonation was appropriately varied in Parts 1 and 2. Band: 6
Estimated Overall Band Score: (6 + 6 + 5 + 6) / 4 = 5.75 → Rounded to 6.0

REFLECTION & DISCUSSION QUESTIONS
1. Score a practice recording using the note template provided. How does your evidence-based score compare to your initial impression?
2. Compare your scoring notes with a colleague's notes for the same recording. Where do you differ? What does this reveal about your scoring habits?
3. Identify a moment in your scoring process where you were influenced by the student's confidence rather than their language quality. What would evidence-based scoring produce?
4. How does the averaging process work if one descriptor is significantly lower than the others? How should this affect the feedback you give the student?

KEY TAKEAWAYS
• Take notes during the test; produce band estimates immediately after.
• Good scoring notes are specific, descriptor-referenced, and example-based.
• Convert notes into band estimates by comparing evidence against band descriptor language — not by relying on overall impression.
• Evidence-based scores must prevail over impressionistic estimates, particularly when a halo effect is suspected.
• The full scoring rationale should be documented and available to support student feedback.

CHAPTER 9

Post-Test Feedback and Teacher Debriefing

The feedback session following a mock speaking test is an equally important professional responsibility. A poorly conducted debrief — one that overwhelms, discourages, or misleads the student — can undermine all the value generated by a well-run test. This chapter outlines how teachers should transition from examiner mode to feedback mode and how to deliver useful, actionable, and honest debriefs.

9.1 When to Return to Coaching Mode

The return to coaching mode should happen cleanly and explicitly — not gradually. The teacher should first complete the full scoring process (see Chapter 8), and then open the feedback session with a clear signal that the formal test phase is over. This might be as simple as:

SAMPLE EXAMINER LANGUAGE
Okay, the test is finished now. I've had a chance to look at your performance, and I'd like to share some feedback with you.
Right — we're out of test mode now. Let me tell you what I noticed.

This signal matters because it recalibrates the student's psychological state. During the test, the student was in a performance orientation — monitoring themselves against an external standard. In the feedback session, they need to shift to a learning orientation — receiving information about their performance in order to improve.

9.2 How to Transition from Examiner to Feedback Mode

The transition should be gradual but explicit. The teacher should:

1. Close the test formally (see closing scripts in Chapter 4).
2. Allow a brief pause — thirty seconds to a minute — while reviewing notes.
3. Open the feedback session with a clear statement of intent.
4. Begin with a brief general statement before descending into specifics.

The teacher should not attempt to give feedback while still in test mode — while asking follow-up questions, while checking the timing, or while the student is still in the room emotionally processing the test. The shift from test to feedback requires a deliberate break.

9.3 How to Give Feedback Without Overwhelming the Student

The most common error in post-test debriefs is information overload. A teacher who has been attentive and taken detailed notes will have identified numerous strengths and weaknesses. The temptation is to share everything. This is almost always counterproductive.

The student cannot act on twelve pieces of feedback simultaneously. They can act on two or three. Effective feedback is prioritized, sequenced, and specific.

A useful framework for feedback delivery:

1. State the overall band estimate and explain briefly what it means.
2. Identify one to two key strengths — specific observations, not general praise.
3. Identify one to two priority areas for improvement — the areas that will most significantly affect the band score if improved.
4. Provide one to two specific, actionable recommendations for each area.
5. Invite the student's own reflection: 'How did you feel it went?'

9.4 How to Explain Scores Responsibly

Students often struggle with score explanations, particularly when the score is lower than they expected. The teacher must explain scores in a way that is accurate, compassionate, and constructive — not defensive, not vague, and not dishonestly optimistic.

The explanation should connect the score to the band descriptor language, not to personal impressions. 'I thought your vocabulary was a 6 because I noticed you using accurate topic-specific vocabulary in Part 3, but you relied heavily on basic adjectives in Part 1 — the band 6 descriptor is about being sufficient to discuss topics at length but with some vocabulary that may be inappropriate' is more useful and credible than 'Your vocabulary was pretty good but not quite 7.'

When a student challenges their score, the teacher should respond by referring to specific examples from the test and to the band descriptor language. If notes are available, they should be shared. This professional approach — evidence-based, transparent, and grounded in descriptor language — builds student trust in the scoring process.

9.5 Distinguishing Test Performance from Long-Term Potential

One of the most important responsibilities the teacher has in the feedback session is helping the student understand that the mock test score is a snapshot, not a sentence. A student who scores Band 5.5 on a mock test today may score Band 6.5 in two months with targeted practice. The score reflects current performance under specific conditions, not ceiling potential.

Equally, the teacher should help the student understand that test-day factors — anxiety, poor sleep, an unusually difficult Part 2 card, a topic the student had no experience with — may have artificially suppressed the score. Conversely, an unusually familiar topic or a particularly relaxed day may have elevated the score slightly above the student's typical level.

The mock test score is most useful when interpreted in the context of multiple assessments over time, alongside classroom observations and other performance indicators.

9.6 Examples of Effective and Poor Debriefing

EFFECTIVE DEBRIEF EXAMPLE
Teacher: 'Okay, we're done with the test now. Let me share what I noticed.'
'Overall, I'd estimate you're around a Band 6 at this point. That means your English is effective for most practical purposes and you can communicate clearly on a wide range of topics — which is genuinely good.'
'One real strength I noticed was your vocabulary in Part 3. When we talked about urban development, you used words like 'infrastructure', 'sustainable', and 'urban sprawl' accurately. That's solid Lexical Resource.'
'The main area I'd work on is grammar consistency. I noticed you had the right idea with complex structures — you tried conditionals and relative clauses — but they often had accuracy errors. For example: you said 'if I will have time' which should be 'if I have time'. This is a really high-frequency pattern worth drilling.'

'Does that make sense? How did you feel the test went from your side?'

POOR DEBRIEF EXAMPLE — What Not To Do
Teacher (immediately after test, before scoring): 'Oh, I think you did really well! Your vocabulary was great, I loved that word you used — what was it? Anyway, I think you're probably around a 7. You just need to be a bit more careful with grammar sometimes.'
Problems with this debrief:
1. No score justification — 'I think around a 7' is an impression, not an evidence-based estimate.
2. Given before proper scoring was completed.
3. Vague feedback — 'be a bit more careful with grammar' provides no actionable guidance.
4. Overly positive framing — may give the student a false impression of their readiness.
5. No reference to band descriptor language.

9.7 Preserving Student Confidence While Being Honest

Honest feedback and preserved confidence are not in conflict — but achieving both requires skill. The teacher should be honest about gaps in performance without being harsh or discouraging about the student's prospects. The tone should be that of a supportive professional who takes both the student and the process seriously.

Effective language for difficult feedback:

SAMPLE EXAMINER LANGUAGE
"Your Part 2 was shorter than ideal — under a minute — and that affected your Fluency score. The good news is that this is something you can directly practise and improve before the real test."
"Your grammar showed some strong range, which is encouraging. The issue is accuracy in complex structures, which tends to improve with targeted practice. Let's talk about what to focus on."
"I want to be honest with you because that's more useful than telling you what you want to hear. Here's what the evidence from your test shows..."

REFLECTION & DISCUSSION QUESTIONS
1. Identify a time when you gave a student feedback that was too positive or too negative. What would an evidence-based, balanced debrief have looked like?
2. How do you explain to a student who is upset by their score that the score reflects language ability, not intelligence or effort?
3. Role-play a debrief in which the student challenges their score. How do you respond using the band descriptor framework?
4. How many pieces of feedback should the average student receive in a debrief? How do you decide which pieces to prioritize?

KEY TAKEAWAYS
• The debrief begins only after the test is fully scored — not during, not immediately after, and not while still in examiner mode.
• Effective feedback is prioritized, specific, evidence-based, and actionable.
• Score explanations must reference band descriptor language and specific performance evidence.
• The mock test score is a snapshot, not a permanent verdict — this perspective must be communicated clearly to students.
• Honesty and compassion are not opposites in feedback — they are complementary professional obligations.

CHAPTER 10

Common Mistakes Teachers Make During Mock Speaking Tests

This chapter consolidates the most frequently observed errors in mock speaking test administration. It is designed for use in teacher training workshops and professional reflection sessions. Each mistake is described, analyzed, and accompanied by a corrective recommendation.

10.1 Catalogue of Common Teacher Mistakes

Mistake 1: Teaching During the Test

Element	Description
What it looks like	Correcting errors mid-response; offering vocabulary; explaining grammar in response to student mistakes; commenting on structure.
Why it is a problem	Transforms the assessment into a lesson; invalidates the test; prevents the collection of unassisted performance evidence.
Effect on validity	Severe — any intervention changes the conditions of the test; scores produced cannot reflect genuine independent ability.
Correction	The teacher must be trained to observe errors silently and note them. A mental trigger — 'I am collecting evidence, not teaching' — can help.

Mistake 2: Over-Smiling or Over-Praising

Element	Description
What it looks like	Broad smiles after strong answers; verbal praise ('Excellent!', 'That's great!', 'Perfect!'); animated expressions of delight at good vocabulary.
Why it is a problem	Communicates evaluative information; can inflate confidence; creates inconsistency between how different students experience the test.
Effect on validity	Moderate to severe — if only some students receive praise, the test conditions are not standardized.
Correction	Practise delivering a consistently warm but neutral expression. Record your own mock test administration and observe your facial behavior.

Mistake 3: Interrupting Too Much

Element	Description
What it looks like	Cutting off students mid-answer; redirecting before students have completed their response; moving to the next question prematurely.
Why it is a problem	Prevents students from demonstrating the full length and quality of their responses; particularly damaging in Part 2 and Part 3.
Effect on validity	Moderate — reduces the evidence base for Fluency and Lexical Resource scoring.
Correction	Develop a habit of waiting for a clear end signal (falling intonation, pause, eye contact with the examiner) before transitioning.

Mistake 4: Simplifying Questions

Element	Description
What it looks like	Re-phrasing Part 3 abstract questions as concrete personal questions; offering the question in simpler language after the first attempt.
Why it is a problem	Reduces the cognitive and linguistic demand of the question; the student's response then reflects a simpler prompt than was intended.
Effect on validity	Severe — scores produced from simplified questions cannot be used to predict real test performance.
Correction	Questions may be repeated verbatim. They may not be paraphrased or simplified. If the student truly cannot understand, this is assessment data.

Mistake 5: Letting the Test Become Too Casual

Element	Description
What it looks like	The teacher begins sharing their own experiences; the interaction drifts into conversation; timing becomes loose; the student begins asking the teacher questions.
Why it is a problem	The test loses its structure and validity; the student performs as they would in a comfortable conversation rather than in a high-stakes assessment.
Effect on validity	Severe — the score from a casual mock test does not predict real IELTS performance.
Correction	The teacher must maintain the formal register of the test from opening to closing, regardless of the relationship with the student.

Mistake 6: Scoring from General Impression Only

Element	Description
What it looks like	Band scores assigned without reference to specific evidence; scores justified with phrases like 'she seemed like a 6.5'.
Why it is a problem	Impression-based scoring is unreliable, subject to halo effect and personal bias, and cannot be defended to students or colleagues.
Effect on validity	Severe in terms of reliability — the scores cannot be trusted.
Correction	Require specific evidence for every band score. If you cannot name a specific instance of language that informs the score, the score is not evidence-based.

Mistake 7: Penalizing Nerves Too Heavily

Element	Description
What it looks like	Scoring Fluency very low because the student hesitated and stumbled; not distinguishing between anxiety-induced disfluency and genuine language deficiency.
Why it is a problem	Anxiety is not a language deficiency; conflating the two produces scores that underestimate the student's genuine ability.
Effect on validity	Moderate — the score underestimates the student's capability and gives misleading information for preparation.
Correction	Note anxiety in the scoring rationale. Score based on the language that was actually produced, not on how it was produced emotionally.

Mistake 8: Confusing Content with Language Proficiency

Element	Description
What it looks like	Scoring a student higher because they discussed an interesting topic intelligently; scoring a student lower because their content was simplistic or culturally unfamiliar.
Why it is a problem	Content knowledge and language ability are different things. IELTS assesses language, not ideas.
Effect on validity	Moderate — the score reflects content bias rather than language evidence.
Correction	Remind yourself before scoring: 'I am scoring the English used to express the content, not the content itself.'

COMMON MISTAKES TO AVOID
Teaching during the test — including correcting, suggesting, or explaining anything mid-test.
Over-praising or over-smiling — creating an inconsistent emotional environment for different students.
Simplifying questions — reducing the cognitive demand of the original prompt.
Allowing the test to become casual — losing timing discipline and formal register.
Scoring from impression only — assigning bands without evidence.
Penalizing nerves — conflating anxiety-induced disfluency with language deficiency.
Confusing content with language — scoring interesting ideas rather than the language used to express them.
Giving different levels of support to different students — unintentional but systematic unfairness.

REFLECTION & DISCUSSION QUESTIONS
1. Which of the mistakes in this chapter do you recognize in your own practice? What would it take to address it?
2. Observe a colleague conducting a mock test. Identify two or three mistakes from this chapter that you observe. How would you raise them constructively?
3. Why do well-intentioned teachers make the mistake of teaching during the test? What pedagogical instincts are responsible?
4. How would you design a peer observation protocol that helps teachers identify their own mock test administration errors?

KEY TAKEAWAYS
• Most common teacher mistakes stem from sound pedagogical instincts applied inappropriately in assessment contexts.
• Awareness of specific mistake categories allows teachers to monitor and correct their own behavior.
• Self-recording and peer observation are the most effective tools for identifying and addressing persistent administration errors.
• The ultimate test of mock test quality is this: could a stranger watching the session identify which student it was? If yes, the conditions were not standardized.

CHAPTER 11

Standardization and Calibration for Teacher Teams

In institutions where multiple teachers conduct mock speaking tests, the challenge of standardization expands from the individual teacher to the collective team. This chapter addresses the institutional practices required to ensure that scores produced by different teachers are comparable, that administration procedures are consistent, and that scoring decisions are defensible.

11.1 Why Standardization Matters at Team Level

If Teacher A consistently rates a Band 5.5 student as a 6.5, and Teacher B consistently rates the same level of student as a 5.0, then the scores they produce are not comparable. Students assessed by Teacher A will receive inflated estimates; students assessed by Teacher B will receive deflated ones. Neither group receives accurate feedback, and the institution loses the ability to track genuine student progress.

Standardization at team level requires agreed practices, shared reference points, and regular calibration — a formal process of comparing scoring judgments and discussing discrepancies.

DEFINITION: Calibration

A formal process in which assessors compare their scoring judgments on the same performance data, discuss discrepancies, and work toward shared understanding of band descriptor application.

11.2 How to Run Scoring Calibration Sessions

Calibration sessions should be conducted at regular intervals — ideally at the beginning of each new intake or assessment period, and again mid-period to catch scoring drift. Each calibration session should:

1. Select two or three recordings of different student performances at different band levels.
2. Ask each teacher to score the recordings independently, using the scoring note template.
3. Compare scores and identify areas of agreement and disagreement.
4. Discuss discrepancies in terms of specific evidence and descriptor language.
5. Reach consensus on the most defensible band score for each recording.
6. Document agreed norms for how specific performance features are scored.

TRAINER NOTE

Calibration works best when the facilitator creates a psychologically safe space for disagreement. Teachers must feel free to hold different scores and defend them using evidence, without feeling judged. The goal is shared understanding, not conformity for its own sake.

11.3 How Inconsistent Examiner Behavior Affects Score Quality

Inconsistency in examiner behavior — not just scoring, but administration — is a form of unfairness. If one teacher always extends Part 3 when students are performing well, those students receive more opportunities to demonstrate language proficiency than students assessed by a teacher who ends Part 3 on time. The additional evidence inflates scores.

Similarly, if one teacher often simplifies Part 3 questions for students who appear to struggle, those students are assessed on a different test from students assessed by a teacher who maintains the original question format.

Administration standardization therefore precedes and underpins scoring standardization. Teams must agree on:

- Identical timing for each part of the test
- Standard question sets or topic card pools that are distributed fairly
- Agreed protocols for handling common incidents (see Chapter 6)
- Agreed scripts for opening, transitioning, and closing the test

11.4 Comparing Teacher Judgments

When two teachers produce significantly different scores for the same recording (a difference of more than 1.0 on any single descriptor is generally significant), the team should explore the following questions:

- What specific evidence did each teacher use to support their score?
- Which band descriptor language did each teacher reference?
- Is there a pattern in the discrepancy — does one teacher consistently score one descriptor higher or lower?
- Is the discrepancy related to a specific performance feature (e.g., how accent is scored, how off-topic responses affect Coherence)?

11.5 Building a Shared Scoring Culture

A shared scoring culture is one in which all teachers on the team have internalized the same understanding of what language evidence corresponds to which band level. This culture is built gradually, through:

- Regular calibration sessions (as described above)
- Shared annotated recordings — a library of scored examples with agreed rationales
- Team discussions of borderline or unusual cases
- New teacher induction processes that include supervised scoring practice before independent administration
- Ongoing peer observation and feedback on administration behavior

11.6 Training New Teachers

New teachers joining a team that conducts mock speaking tests should not be permitted to administer or score independently until they have:

1. Read this handbook in full and discussed its contents with an experienced colleague.
2. Observed at least two mock speaking tests administered by experienced teachers.
3. Participated in at least one calibration session, scoring independently and then comparing scores.
4. Conducted at least one supervised mock test with an observer, followed by a full debrief.
5. Reached acceptable agreement with the team on at least three calibration recordings.

11.7 Practical Calibration Activities

Activity 1: Score Comparison Workshop

Provide the team with a recording (10 to 15 minutes) of a mock speaking test. Ask each teacher to score independently using the scoring template. Display scores anonymously. Discuss the range, identify the largest discrepancies, and work through the evidence for each descriptor.

Activity 2: Transcript Calibration

Provide a written transcript of a mock test (approximately two to three minutes of speech). Ask teachers to score Fluency and Coherence and Grammatical Range based on the transcript alone, then compare. Discuss what information the transcript reveals and what it obscures (e.g., Pronunciation cannot be assessed from a transcript).

Activity 3: Video Mock Analysis

Show a video of a mock test with the sound off. Ask teachers to observe and note examiner behavior: What is the examiner doing well? What mistakes are being made? This builds awareness of non-verbal examiner behavior.

Activity 4: Examiner Language Audit

Provide a transcript of an examiner's questions and responses. Ask teachers to identify any language that violates the neutrality requirements set out in Chapter 5. Discuss why each violation is problematic.

Activity 5: Incident Response Case Discussion

Present case scenarios from Chapter 6. Ask teachers to identify the appropriate response independently, then compare and discuss. Focus on cases where the teacher's natural instinct conflicts with the appropriate examiner response.

REFLECTION & DISCUSSION QUESTIONS
1. How would you explain the purpose of a calibration session to a colleague who believes their scoring is already accurate?
2. What institutional mechanisms could you introduce to reduce scoring drift over time?
3. How do you create psychological safety in a calibration session so that teachers feel comfortable defending — and revising — their scores?
4. Identify the three areas of administration inconsistency most likely to occur in your institutional context. What specific protocols would address them?

KEY TAKEAWAYS
• Team-level standardization requires agreed administration procedures, not just agreed scoring standards.
• Calibration sessions are the primary tool for building shared scoring judgment across a teaching team.
• Score discrepancies of more than 1.0 on any descriptor require investigation — they indicate either different evidence bases or different interpretations of descriptor language.
• New teachers should be supervised and calibrated before independent administration.
• A shared scoring culture is built gradually through regular practice, shared reference recordings, and open professional discussion.

CHAPTER 12

Workshop Applications and Training Activities

This final chapter converts the handbook's content into practical workshop activities. It is designed for use by trainer-facilitators running teacher development sessions on mock speaking test administration. Each activity can be adapted for in-person or online workshop formats.

12.1 Role-Play Activities

Activity 12.1.A: The Examiner vs. The Teacher

Purpose: To help teachers experience and distinguish the difference between teacher behavior and examiner behavior through role-play.

Procedure: In pairs, one teacher plays the candidate and one plays the examiner. The facilitator first asks the 'examiner' to conduct a five-minute interaction as they would naturally in class — being as supportive, corrective, and encouraging as they like. The facilitator then asks the same pair to repeat the interaction using strictly examiner language and behavior from Chapter 5. The pair then discusses what was different and what felt uncomfortable.

Debrief Focus: What was hardest to suppress? What did the candidate notice about the difference in feel between the two interactions?

Activity 12.1.B: Part 3 Neutral Probing Practice

Purpose: To practise asking abstract questions neutrally and using follow-up prompts that elicit language without leading.

Procedure: Provide a set of Part 3 questions on a card. In pairs, one teacher asks questions from the card and the other responds. The 'examiner' may only use language from the approved examiner language list in Chapter 5. An observer watches and raises a hand each time the examiner uses inappropriate language.

Debrief Focus: Which violations occurred most often? What was the instinct behind each violation?

12.2 Observer Checklist Tasks

Activity 12.2: Live Mock Observation

Purpose: To develop observation skills and increase awareness of specific examiner behavior patterns.

Procedure: One teacher conducts a mock speaking test while a second observes using the Observer Checklist (see Appendix C). After the test, the observer provides structured feedback using the checklist. The teacher who was observed shares their own experience of the interaction.

Observer Checklist Sample Items:

- Did the examiner maintain a consistent, neutral tone throughout?
- Did the examiner use any evaluative language — verbal or non-verbal?
- Did the examiner repeat questions at the same pace and in the same wording?
- Did the examiner take notes without alarming the candidate?
- Did the examiner use appropriate transition language between parts?
- Was timing discipline maintained throughout?
- Did the examiner simplify any questions?

12.3 Scoring Practice Sessions

Activity 12.3.A: Solo Scoring Practice

Purpose: To practise applying band descriptors to a performance sample independently.

Procedure: Provide each teacher with a recording (10 to 15 minutes) and the scoring note template. Ask each teacher to score independently, writing evidence-based notes for each descriptor. Allow thirty minutes. Compare scores and discuss.

Activity 12.3.B: Borderline Case Discussion

Purpose: To develop judgment about the most challenging scoring decisions.

Procedure: Select two recordings — one that sits clearly between two bands (e.g., at the boundary between Band 5 and Band 6 for Lexical Resource). Ask the team to argue the case

for the higher and lower band in turn, using only descriptor language and specific evidence. The facilitator moderates and helps the team reach a consensus.

12.4 Calibration Workshop

Activity 12.4: Full Calibration Session

Purpose: To standardize scoring judgment across the team.

Procedure: Select three recordings representing approximately Band 4.5, Band 6.0, and Band 7.5. Score all three independently. Compare all four descriptor scores for each recording. For any descriptor where teachers differ by more than 1.0, discuss evidence and reach consensus. Document the agreed scores and the reasoning behind them.

Target Outcome: All teachers should be within 0.5 of each other on each descriptor for all three recordings before the calibration session concludes.

12.5 Reflection and Self-Audit Tools

Activity 12.5: Teacher Self-Audit

Purpose: To promote honest self-reflection on administration practices.

Procedure: Provide each teacher with the Mock Examiner Self-Evaluation Checklist (see Appendix D). Ask teachers to complete it independently and honestly, rating themselves on each item. In small groups, teachers share one area of strength and one area for development. The group discusses specific strategies for addressing the development area.

Activity 12.6: Post-Observation Discussion Protocol

Purpose: To structure feedback conversations between teachers after peer observation.

Procedure: After a peer observation, the observer initiates a structured discussion using the following protocol:

1. State one specific thing the examiner did well, with an example.
2. State one specific thing the examiner might consider changing, with an example.
3. Ask the examiner: 'How did that part of the test feel from your perspective?'
4. Together, identify one concrete change to practise in the next mock test.

REFLECTION & DISCUSSION QUESTIONS
1. Which workshop activity do you think would be most valuable for your teaching team at this time? Why?
2. How would you adapt these activities for an online professional development session?
3. What resistance might you encounter from colleagues when introducing calibration sessions? How would you address it?
4. How would you sustain the professional development momentum built through these activities over the course of a full academic year?

KEY TAKEAWAYS
• Workshop activities are most effective when they replicate real mock test conditions and generate authentic discussion from concrete experience.
• Role-play, observation, and scoring practice are the three core methodologies for teacher development in this area.
• Calibration sessions should be structured, evidence-based, and documented — not casual score-comparison conversations.
• Self-audit tools build metacognitive awareness of administration habits and are most powerful when combined with peer feedback.
• Sustained professional development requires recurring activity — not a single workshop — and institutional commitment to standardization as a shared value.

APPENDICES

Appendix A: Glossary of Key Terms

Term	Definition
Band Descriptor	The official criteria used to evaluate IELTS Speaking performance: Fluency and Coherence, Lexical Resource, Grammatical Range and Accuracy, and Pronunciation.
Calibration	A formal process in which assessors compare scoring judgments on the same performance to reach shared understanding of band levels.
Coherence	The logical organization and connection of ideas in speech, assessed independently from fluency.
Collocation	Natural word combinations in English (e.g., 'make a decision', not 'do a decision').
Elicitation	The use of standardized questions and prompts to draw language from a candidate without providing assistance.
Examiner Bias	Any tendency to score based on factors unrelated to language proficiency, such as personality, nationality, or prior relationship.
Evidence-Based Scoring	Assigning band scores based on specific, observable instances of language performance rather than general impressions.
Fairness	The principle that all candidates are assessed under equivalent conditions with equal access to the same opportunities to perform.
Fluency	The smoothness and continuity of speech delivery, independent of its logical organization.
Lexical Resource	The range, accuracy, and appropriateness of vocabulary used, including the ability to paraphrase.
Neutral Support	A testing environment that is calm, professional, and safe without providing any assistance that influences language output.
Non-Leading Behavior	Examiner conduct that does not suggest expected answers or steer the candidate toward particular responses.
Reliability	The consistency of scores across different assessors and occasions; the extent to which the test produces stable, reproducible results.
Standardization	The process of ensuring that all candidates experience equivalent test conditions and are assessed by the same criteria.
Validity	The degree to which the test measures what it claims to measure — in this case, genuine independent speaking proficiency.

Appendix B: Scoring Note Template

This template should be used during and immediately after each mock speaking test. Teachers should organize observations by descriptor, noting both strengths and limitations with specific examples.

Field	Entry
Candidate Name / ID	
Date	
Examiner	
Test Duration	
Part 2 Topic Card Used	
Technical Issues (if any)	

Descriptor	Positive Evidence (Specific Examples)	Negative Evidence (Specific Examples)	Initial Band Range
Fluency			
Coherence			
Lexical Resource			
Grammatical Range			
Grammatical Accuracy			
Pronunciation			

Summary Field	Entry
Estimated Band: Fluency & Coherence	
Estimated Band: Lexical Resource	
Estimated Band: Grammatical Range & Accuracy	
Estimated Band: Pronunciation	
Calculated Overall Speaking Band	
Key Strengths to Share in Feedback	
Priority Development Areas for Student	
Contextual Notes (anxiety, technical issues, etc.)	

Appendix C: Mock Examiner Observation Checklist

To be completed by a peer observer during a mock speaking test. Each item should be rated: Yes / Partially / No, with brief notes.

Observation Item	Rating	Notes
The examiner opened the test with a standardized, professional greeting.		
The examiner confirmed the candidate's name appropriately.		
The examiner's tone was warm and consistent throughout.		
The examiner avoided evaluative language (verbal praise or correction).		
The examiner maintained appropriate eye contact.		
The examiner's facial expression was neutral and attentive.		
Questions were delivered clearly and at natural pace.		
When repeating questions, the examiner used the same wording and pace.		
The examiner used only approved follow-up prompts.		
Part 1 timing was maintained (4-5 minutes).		
The Part 2 task card and preparation instructions were delivered correctly.		
The one-minute preparation time was respected.		
Part 2 timing was maintained (1-2 minutes speaking).		
Part 3 questions were asked in their original form without simplification.		
Part 3 timing was maintained (4-5 minutes).		
The examiner took notes unobtrusively.		
The test was closed with a standardized, professional statement.		
No feedback was given during or immediately after the test.		

Appendix D: Mock Examiner Self-Evaluation Checklist

Complete this checklist after conducting a mock speaking test. Be as honest as possible. Use it as the basis for a peer discussion or personal reflection.

Self-Evaluation Item	Always	Sometimes	Rarely / Never
I maintain a consistent, warm-but-neutral tone throughout the test.			
I avoid evaluative praise or reactions during the test.			
I resist the urge to correct or comment on errors I notice.			
I repeat questions verbatim rather than paraphrasing or simplifying.			
I manage timing strictly for all three parts of the test.			
I take notes organized by band descriptor.			
My scoring is based on specific evidence, not general impression.			
I score each band descriptor independently.			
I avoid awarding higher scores to confident or likable students.			
I do not penalize nerves unless they measurably impact language quality.			
I give feedback only after the test is fully scored.			
My feedback is prioritized, specific, and evidence-based.			
I could justify every band score I assign with specific evidence.			

After completing the checklist, identify:

- One item rated 'Always' — this is a strength to model and maintain.
- One item rated 'Sometimes' — this is a development area to focus on in the next mock test.
- One item rated 'Rarely / Never' — this is a priority for professional development and peer observation.

Appendix E: Incident Response Quick-Reference Guide

Use this guide during or immediately after an unexpected situation in a mock speaking test.

Situation	Immediate Response	Standard Language	What to Avoid
Candidate freezes / goes silent	Wait 5-8 seconds; then offer a standard prompt	"Take your time." / "Shall I repeat the question?"	Do not provide content or simplify the question
Candidate becomes emotional	Pause test; allow composure moment	"Take a moment if you need to."	Do not give evaluative reassurance
Candidate says 'I don't understand'	Repeat question once, same wording, same pace	"Certainly. (Repeat question.)"	Do not explain or simplify
Candidate asks 'Is my answer okay?'	Respond briefly and neutrally; continue	"I can't comment during the test. Let's continue."	Do not evaluate the answer
Candidate goes off-topic	Allow brief completion; redirect	"Thank you. I'd like to return to the original question."	Do not interrupt mid-sentence unless very extended
Candidate gives very short answer	Use one follow-up prompt	"Can you tell me a little more about that?"	Do not use more than two follow-up prompts
Candidate appears to use memorized answer	Continue; ask a follow-up that deviates from the expected topic	Ask a personalized, specific follow-up	Do not accuse or challenge the candidate
Technical issues (online)	Pause timer; attempt reconnection	"We appear to have a technical issue. I'll pause the test."	Do not score the affected period
Candidate finishes Part 2 in under 1 minute	Use standard Part 2 extension prompt	"Is there anything else you would like to add?"	Do not suggest content or prompt with ideas
Candidate asks for vocabulary help	Decline gently; encourage paraphrase	"Try to explain it in a different way if you can."	Do not provide the word